

The Aesthetics and Logic of *Wanghong* in Postdigital China

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Introduction: *Wanghong* as Concept(s)

The term *wanghong* is a shorthand term for *wangluo hongren* (literally ‘person popular on the internet’, while *hong* is a metaphor for ‘fame barometer’), which has been completely eclipsed by its abbreviated form since 2015. The shorthand term then grew exponentially to have a life of its own. It began as a simple term that generically referred to internet fame or rather an ordinary person who is also ‘famous on the internet’. In the late 1990s and early 2000s, internet lives (in the form of discussion boards and blogs) were still ‘virtual’, distinctively separate from ‘real’ or offline lives. At this point, internet-incubated celebrities often did not intersect with ‘traditional’ movie stars and TV celebrities and remained largely subcultural. While this relative marginality restricted the possibilities of converting this fame into sustainable income, let alone lucrative profits, it also constituted some truly novel ways of becoming famous online and was a pivotal moment as digital culture started to redefine celebritydom. For instance, the early meme deities Xilige (‘Brother Sharp’, active circa 2010; see Jeffreys and Wang 2012) and Furong jiejie (‘Sister Lotus’, active circa 2005; see Roberts 2010) mainly proliferated on web forums or discussion boards. They were ‘the culmination of a series of circumstances and events in many ways highlight the illiberality and capriciousness of the internet’ (Roberts 2010, 220) at the time.

With the uptake of Chinese platform capitalism since the mid-2010s (Zhang 2020; Wang and Yu 2021)—in particular, livestreaming and short video platforms in conjunction with e-commerce platforms—internet-native celebrities took the main stage. The previous marginality was then superseded by pervasive business rationality and a default entrepreneur mentality in the general social factory of platform

capitalism. This logic of commercial rationality is qualitatively and quantitatively different from the celebrification of the past digital subcultural figures, whose internet fame was often accidental, unpredictable, and therefore singular. The algorithmised influencers ‘fundamentally orient themselves to anticipate the incessant tweaks and oft-unforeseen updates of algorithmic systems’ (Duffy et al. 2021, 8). Their practices often follow a platform-dominant commercial logic that is repeatable and habitually imitated by aspiring influencers, influencer agencies, and dedicated training programmes.

While terms such as ‘influencers’ and ‘microcelebrities’ (Abidin 2018; Abidin and Brown 2018) have become universal in the West, the dominant ‘equivalent’ terms in China are still *wanghong* and KOL (key opinion leaders). However, I do not think an ambivalent cultural and socioeconomic equivalence between influencer and *wanghong* warrants a straightforward adoption of these existing academic and colloquial definitions in English. While I am not arguing that China has its own entirely independent semiotic systems of ‘influencers,’ I insist on using the vernacular *wanghong* rather than translating it because *wanghong* as continuing conceptual (re)creations extends far beyond the original meaning ‘net red (fame)’ or ‘famous people online’.

While this collection is mostly concerned with how digitality has transformed the human aspect of celebrity culture, this chapter is not focused on *wanghong* as human influencers but on how the very fabric of celebritydom is now intertwined with design aesthetics, algorithmic circulation, and (post)digital culture in general. Much of the existing research on *wanghong*—for example, Craig, Lin, and Cunningham’s (2021) holistic approach to *wanghong* as ‘social media entertainment’ and Xu and Zhao’s (2019) research on the changes in female *wanghong*—predominantly considers *wanghong* as human subjects. However, this chapter is a speculative treatise on *wanghong* that mostly circumvents the existing framework of microcelebrity or internet influencers that focus on *people*. Beyond internet celebrities, I believe the study of *wanghong* as a wider socioeconomic-aesthetic phenomenon has much to contribute to celebrity/microcelebrity studies. In this context, I argue that *wanghong* as it stands today is far more complex than mere internet fame or ‘influential’ famous people online; instead, it is deeply entrenched in contemporary everyday life and mass culture in China. The term has become a prefix or adjective that is attached to a great many objects, contexts, aesthetics, spaces, and design practices in everyday life.¹ To name a few examples, *wanghong* city (Chaoyang Trap House 2021), *wanghong* space, *wanghong* beverage, *wanghong* architecture, *wanghong* gallery, and *wanghong* café. In many cases, the spaces and objects under discussion may not be famous at all, not even in the ‘micro’ sense, but attached to the adjective *wanghong* nonetheless.

1. The idea of defining celebrity as an adjective instead of a noun is not new, as it is seen previously in the work of Marwick and boyd (2011; see also Jerslev and Mortensen 2016).



Figure 14.1: The main text on the sign reads: ‘The *wanghong* building, finally, has a *wang-hong* nail beauty shop!’. Photo taken in Wuhan by the author.



Figure 14.2: The tagline of the store reads: ‘Global web celebrity snacks direct supply’. Photo taken in Guangzhou by the author.



Figure 14.3: The sign of the clinic reads: ‘*Wanghong* bone-setting (a Chinese medicinal massage technique) and acupuncture’. Photo taken in Zhuhai by the author.

For example, in Figure 14.1, this river-view commercial high-rise office building in Wuhan is popular for its concentration of bars, coffee shops, and restaurants; therefore the first instance of ‘*wanghong* building’ in the tagline refers to actual ‘internet fame’, whereas the second instance of ‘*wanghong* nail salon’ does not refer to a specific internet reputation but attempts to communicate a style. In Figure 14.2, ‘*wanghong* snacks’ can refer to actual popularity in terms of sales or speculatively in the sense of marketing. In Figure 14.3, the adjective *wanghong* attached to bone-setting and acupuncture intends to provoke a certain degree of confusion as well as curiosity—and to agonise over the absurdity and how extensive the fad has spread. What unites all these instances is not internet fame per se, but a replicable commercial and/or aesthetic logic of datafication and standardisation in a continuous reality between internet platforms, user practices, and entrepreneurs/designers. The manifestation of *wanghong* aesthetics is largely ‘based on computational language, algorithms and self-replicating systems of code’ (Contreras-Koterbay and Mirocha 2016, 12)—for instance, Dianping and Xiaohongshu’s recommendation algorithms, image filters, or user- or bot-generated likes and comments.

From the above examples, it is almost impossible to pinpoint the exact definition of *wanghongfeng* or *wanghong* style in the aesthetic sense. However, as Cramer



Figure 14.4: A hair salon is literally named ‘ins.style’; the tagline reads: ‘Japanese-style dye, fashionable hair extension’. Photo taken in Wuhan by the author.

(2017, 124) writes, ‘technology is never pure research or pure formula, but a hybrid of research and its practical application, it also includes the metaphors, buzzwords, and hypes used in its development and deployment’. Studying the metaphor, buzzword, and hype of *wanghongfeng* is one such opportunity to study the entanglements of technologies and aesthetics. *Wanghongfeng* used in the context of a nail beauty shop could be alluding to its repository of nail designs or the interior design or the sheer number of influencers who have visited the shop. The term is deliberately obscure to intimate and circulate a *public feeling* as well as signal a keyword to the all-encompassing black box of algorithm despite not making sense at all linguistically.

Moreover, *wanghongfeng* is akin to other Chinese internet vernaculars such as *ins feng* or ‘Instagram style’ (see Figure 14.4), *gongye feng* or ‘industrial style’, and *xinglendan feng* or ‘frigid/asexual style’—all these adjectives could be a generic reference to minimalism in interior design or fashion but sometimes completely different aesthetics depending on the context. With enough datasets and variables generated under keywords such as *wanghong* and *gongye feng*, these ‘hot search’ terms become anchors where new tastes and trends are launched, circulated, and

discovered. These platform-administered trends can in turn directly *influence* the design of physical space, consumer products, and marketing tactics.

Since 2015, *wanghong* has become such a ‘hot concept’ that ‘quickly got attached to various people and objects; *wanghong* became a container, whatever things remotely related will be tossed in’ (Tang et al. 2017, 21).² *Wanghong* manifests itself as a nested network of concepts hatched by software engineers, economists, designers, contemporary semioticians (i.e., PR/marketing writers), photographers, and so forth. The prolific conceptual production around *wanghong* today aptly echoes Deleuze and Guattari’s (1994, 10–11) comments on the conceptual creativity during their time:

The most shameful moment came when computer science, marketing, design, and advertising, all the disciplines of communication, seized hold of the word concept itself and said: This is our concern, we are the creative ones, we are the ideas men! . . . How could philosophy, an old person, compete against young executives in a race for the universals of communication for a marketable form of the concept, *Merz*?

I am not lamenting the overwhelming ‘shameless and inane’ (Deleuze and Guattari 1994, 11) creations of new concepts attached to *wanghong*. I aim to situate or locate these concept creations in their condition of creation. Specifying this condition will help displace the current discourse from socioeconomics and marketing jargon—for example, the Chinese state sees *wanghong* as useful when it revitalises the slowing consumer economy but otherwise as a vulgar cultural malaise that needs to be cured—towards a much less explored area of aesthetics and politics. I want to redefine *wanghong* as a concept, or a constantly mutating network of concepts, that relies on its propensity to replicate, standardise, aestheticise, and unrelentingly commercialise in a postdigital process. In the following, I will first contextualise the postdigital condition of contemporary China as a continuous reality between users, platforms, and designers. Then I will demonstrate the postdigital celebrification of urban spaces via two examples: one *wanghong* café and one cultural-industrial cluster in Hangzhou.

The Postdigital Condition of Banal Celebrification

Following the early history of *wanghong*, my colleague and I have already outlined a chronology of the topological structure of *wanghong* elsewhere (Zhang and de Seta 2018), where we built generations of internet celebrities into stacks of infrastructure, platforms, and vernacular content from the late nineties to present day. While we did not intend to create a discrete periodisation—since the development of different types of internet celebrities and platforms do overlap and do not necessarily

2. Original quote is in Chinese; translation is my own.

replace each other completely—this topology was still largely presented as a linear model. In retrospect, the unintended effect of this seemingly linear periodisation is an illusion of inevitable linear progression. This argument of progression is widely adopted in discussing the maturity of a replicable commercial model in the popular discourse on *wanghong*. This lingering symptom of linear historicisation coincides with the critique of ‘a sanitized linear sense of media cultural progress’ (Bishop, Gansing, and Parikka 2017, 19) from the theories of the postdigital that were sketched by Florian Cramer (2014) and others.

By invoking the postdigital, I am not advocating for neophobia, in the case of a Luddite or the fetish of reinvented ‘analogue’ aesthetics or technologies,³ nor a distinct period or era after the digital. I follow a much messier model, a ‘membrane’ (Pepperell and Punt 2000) or conflation between the IRL (‘in real life’) and digital. This postdigital model ‘acknowledge[s] the current state of technology whilst rejecting the implied conceptual shift of the “digital revolution”’ (Pepperell and Punt 2000, 2). Instead of proposing the digital era as a disruption or rupture, we can understand it as a presupposition that we create to make sense of societal changes where everything is already digital. The membrane of the postdigital is a continuous reality where the digital and IRL are all concurrent, and ‘inevitably a constituent of each thing it lies between’ (Pepperell and Punt 2000, 164). The postdigital is not a ‘turn’ but a ‘processual condition that our civilization is based on’ (Contreras-Koterbay and Mirocha 2016, 24).

As Cramer (2014, 14) writes, ‘the “digital” in “post-digital” should not be understood in any technical-scientific or media-theoretical sense, but, rather, in the way the term is broadly used in popular culture’. As I alluded to earlier, the multiplicity of *wanghong*’s meanings as an adjective is better understood through popular culture instead of media theory. One of the best examples of ‘postdigital China’ (de Seta 2018) is the compulsory presence of smartphones and mobile apps in everyday life. Smartphones in conjunction with laminated QR codes became the main everyday computing interfaces for almost every aspect of daily life from accessing public spaces and transport to online and offline transactions in post-COVID China. As I have illustrated elsewhere (Zhang 2022), the online and offline processes and practices have become so congruent that smartphones and especially the installation of WeChat are now required for essential daily activities such as basic mobility in all public spaces, especially under the now defunct regime of Zero Covid. Disconnection from smartphones is no longer a matter of boycotting social media but a basic need in everyday life.

In a mundane scenario of looking for a restaurant for dinner on the app Dianping—the default public repository of ‘Things to do and places to visit’ (the

3. *Wanghong* aesthetics imitate a diverse range of (life)styles that sometimes specifically brand itself as anti-digital or a disenchantment with digital, often associated with the otherwise-known-as ‘hipsterism’ in the West—for instance, a disembodied nostalgia for fax machine and typewriters among the young people who have never experienced these technologies when they were still commonplace.

platform's official tagline)—the search results of nearby restaurants are not simply sorted and displayed according to our tastes but also the statistical attributes of the algorithm, online presentations of the shops, customer feedback, sponsorship, and so forth. We discover and navigate the city via these ranking lists, ratings, annotated maps, user-generated comments, and images. As Contreras-Koterbay and Mirocha (2016, 12) write:

The software used in mapping programmes transforms the way we interact with and navigate a geographic location but it also has aesthetic qualities that work behind the scenes . . . whether we like a restaurant, bookshop, art gallery, local neighbourhood or even an entire city may be dependent on the way information about all of these is presented to us and, even further, how that information evolves in databases controlled by the software.

Aligning the conceptual production of *wanghong* to the theories of the post-digital creates an opportunity for cultural analytics that are both 'an aesthetic and a logic' (Berry 2105, 45). The result of the computational 'manipulation' appears like customisation, but the effect is still standardisation, which is contrary to the post-Fordist celebration of personality and choice. The standardisation of industrial capitalism never withered away, as it is revived via 'multi-layered software, black-box hardware and ubiquitous computing' (Berry 2105, 39) of internet platforms. Furthermore, this standardisation lies in both commercial logic and aesthetics. The whole premise of the '*wanghong* economy' is that it does not simply rely on influencers promoting or selling products online but also acts as a replicable chain of mass production and consumption. The most documented example of this commercial logic is the Taobao village (Lin et al. 2021), where manufacturing, marketing, and logistics are carried out vertically in the same locale.

This chapter focuses on another aspect of this replicable logic that manifests as aesthetic choices, which especially translates into spatiality and product or interior design. For example, in Chongqing's case as a *wanghong* city, the *wanghong* aesthetics embodies a specific (self)orientalising imagination of cyberpunk, neon lights, verticality, and high-rises (Roast 2021). This Chongqing-esque aesthetics is then fragmented into certain design tropes that are captured, sorted, and recommended by computational regimes on platforms such as Dianping and Xiaohongshu. These user-generated images—often rendered via photographic techniques from optical lenses to filters to image cropping, posted with hashtags and keywords—are algorithmically remediated; such digital objects and labels then directly contribute to the manufacture and standardisation of aesthetic choices in accelerated cycles of urban renewal.

Let us return to the earlier notion of *wanghong* as an adjective in connection with the idea of celebrification. Celebrity studies increasingly 'places fame on a continuum, rather than as a bright line that separates individuals' (Marwick and boyd 2011, 140; emphasis added). In discussing influencers, banal celebrification

refers to ‘the continuous production and reproduction of celebrity’ (Jerslev and Mortensen 2016, 2). My own contribution to celebrity studies is an abstraction of the celebrification process applied to not just people but any objects and places in a relational ecosystem. *Wanghong*, in contrast to the initial emergence of accidental and untamed internet celebrities, is the flagship cultural product of contemporary capitalism and emblematic of the pervasive ‘ongoing condition’ (Contreras-Koterbay and Mirocha 2016, 40) of the postdigital. As I will demonstrate, the scale of *wanghong* as a conceptual network far exceeds the influencer industry (e.g., *wanghong* incubators that specialise in training professional streamers and content). The post-digital condition of banal celebrification is now standardising almost every aspect of contemporary Chinese consumer society from economic models to aesthetic judgements. However, I am not arguing that this postdigital condition is all grim without recourse but that *wanghong* is a ‘conceptual’ opportunity to understand the consumer society and celebrification in contemporary China.

A recent Chinese translation of Gabriel Tarde’s *Laws of Imitation* (1903) published in 2020 dubbed Gabriel Tarde as the ‘founding (*bizu*) *wanghong*’ theorist in its promotional tagline coined by the Chinese publisher. This is an interesting proposition given the intellectual climate in China that unfailingly cites another famous crowd psychologist Gustave Le Bon (2002) whenever discussing the phenomenon of *wanghong*. Renowned cultural critic Wang Xiaofeng (2015) writes:

Chinese popular culture has increasingly become an instrument for *bianxian* (conversion to cash or profits) in the most direct, simple, and vulgar way possible. Not only have the producers lost common sense, but the audience nurtured under this culture has collectively degenerated into consumerist animals with no aesthetic judgements and standards. [translation is my own]

This assessment argues that the standardising effect of *wanghong* is the inevitable result of the social factory that is ‘influencerizing’ everything—from the viral objects (e.g., a video, image, or product) to the ‘mass hallucination through the unconscious crowd’ (Sampson 2012, 162). From this rationale, the banalisation of *wanghong* as a condition necessitates an immunological response from the state hence the crackdowns on the overt vulgarity and ostentation of internet celebrities. At this juncture, the introduction of Tardean epidemiological relations can help us understand the social process of *wanghong* as an alternative to Wang Xiaofeng’s pessimistic take on mass culture. Tarde’s theory of hypnotic image and affective processes of contagion is open-ended and extended by technologies. The assumed roles of hypnotiser and hypnotised are blurred, instead of enforcing the distinction between the influencer and their followers. From this perspective, we can ‘explore new exploitable social assemblages of affective contagious encounter’ (Sampson 2012, 3). In the postdigital condition of banal celebrification, the micro-imitations in Tarde’s terms are predominantly re-modulated by computational technologies to condition societies, cities, and markets. Neuromarketing is now also algorithmic,

and everyone is an influencer—as demonstrated by the following case of *wanghong* cafés.

The Rise and Fall and Rise of *Wanghong* Cafés

The production of a *wanghong* coffee shop is a more intricate matter than simply inviting influencers to hype up the venue on social media. For example, in the case of a long-standing popular café in a local community, the online presence of the café creates only an unintended ‘extra’ value and new customers (especially one-off visitors) on top of the relatively sustainable local clientele. The recommendations by the influencers who ‘discover’ the shop and online exposure *can* boost the shop to the *wanghong* status but there are no ‘extra’ proactive efforts needed from the owners. In this case, the status of *wanghong* only refers to its literal sense—it can be purely accidental, and the process is arbitrary and therefore not replicable. This accidental model has evolved into a systemic reproduction coordinated between entrepreneurs, designers, influencers, and platforms. The manufacture of *wanghong* cafés involves a constellation of design modules, marketing techniques, and intricate (often folkloric if not technical) knowledge of how platforms work.

The Tardean imitative process of repetition, adaptation, and opposition, which describes how small influences build into overwhelming trends, should be also updated to include a consideration of the ‘network unconscious’ (Sampson 2012, 165) of algorithms. The genesis of a fashion or trend on Dianping has become rather centralised and reliant on large datasets. As Mull (2022) notes, ‘when enough brands and retailers begin using these inventory tactics and trend-prediction methods, the results homogenize over time.’ The propensity to copy as informed by the algorithmic trendspotting is a fundamental feature of the *wanghong* model. As an excerpt of my observation of coffee shops in Shanghai, Hangzhou, and Wuhan from 2019 to 2021, I will outline this circular process in the following. It should be noted that the process can begin in any of the following steps and the model is only part of my ideation process instead of a process summarised by industrial insiders.

First, the design of a *wanghong* coffee shop can be initiated by trending aesthetics on social media platforms: for example, concrete texture, mirrors, open ceilings, and metallic surfaces are currently considered *wanghong* design tropes. This aesthetic must be demonstrated by good enough statistics of online attention—or *liuliang* (literally ‘traffic’), which is another extremely popular concept for online attention—but does not necessarily translate to offline sales. *Wanghongfeng* here is not an inspiration or abstraction but concretised into a particular set of specifications of interior design tropes: to imitate and replicate the design tropes at low cost and high efficiency. Even the selection of decorative objects and furniture are often found via specific search terms on Taobao, which further streamlines an algorithm-directed industrial chain of (re)producing *wanghong* spaces.

Moreover, the operators or owners of *wanghong* coffeeshops are often very adept at promoting the shop on platforms such as Dianping, Instagram, and Xiaohongshu and boosting their rankings. The second step of the circular process includes the following:

1. Hiring a social media team—or at least spending a significant amount of labour time on—running social media accounts of the coffeeshop;
2. Proactively inviting influencers to *tandian* (literally ‘visit the shop’) and promote the café through their social media accounts;
3. Encouraging customers to rate, write comments, and post pictures of the space on various platforms and often rewarding the customer with a discount or coupon upon confirmation;
4. Buying ad space on location-based apps such as Dianping, although this is not preferred as it will be labelled as an advertisement in the search result and therefore often avoided;
5. Employing the ‘water army’⁴ to manipulate the algorithm with a large stream of junk data (e.g., nonsensical comments) in order to boost its search rank, which is preferable to buying ad space since it hides the ad label.

The cost of running these online operations can be far higher than the actual interior design of the shop or even rent in second or third-tier cities—this fact is frequently brought up during interviews when discussing the key feature of *wanghong* cafés. It should be noted that, in the space of the coffee business, multinational conglomerates such as Starbucks are usually not in direct competition with small cafés, because they occupy very different locations and clientele.

The third step builds upon a certain degree of existing online visibility to kick off actual consumption: long queues, a flood of reviews from visitors and returning customers, one-off visitors posing and taking photos in the shop, and so on. This stream of customer-generated content would appear to be more ‘authentic’ and potentially becomes trendsetting in the local community therefore initiating the first step again—that is, encouraging other aspiring cafés to replicate the same ‘design + social media’ formula. This formula also applies to the core product—coffee. For example, seasonable ‘creative coffees’ (*chuanyi kafei*) mix new ingredients beyond conventional milk, soy milk, or soda water, such as various assortments of fruits, syrup, sesame sauce, pickles, and alcohol. These trendsetting cycles of outlandish mixology in cafés are perhaps a uniquely Chinese phenomenon especially influenced by another popular drink—bubble tea.

The following case study does not strictly follow the steps outlined above, which summarises an ideal cycle of the postdigital process, but it showcases how a café that does not proactively adopt the *wanghong* logic gets co-opted by the process anyway.

4. The water army is the internet vernacular to describe the ‘army’ of paid posters to swarm the social media page (e.g., Dianping) of a café to leave positive ratings and reviews. This ‘army’ can be just a few workers operating on a click farm of hundreds of smartphones or bots depending on the platform they operate on.

In January and June 2022, I interviewed Mr He (pseudonym) twice, the owner of a coffee shop on a historical street Xiaohe Zhijie in Hangzhou. This coffee shop was ranked the number-one café in the district on Dianping in 2019 and 2020, and it was therefore a *wanghong* café in the strictest sense of the term. As Mr He disclosed, his café was opened in 2019 and ‘accidentally’ benefited from a change in Dianping’s user level rank system (users can level up by posting reviews and receiving feedback for reviews): originally the highest user rank used to be 7 then was raised to 8 in early 2019. This change prompted many users to look for newly opened restaurants and cafés to post reviews on and eventually level up. This change not only motivated influencers but also ordinary users who were active reviewers and critics on the platform. ‘My coffeeshop’s Dianping page was caught up in this tidal wave of incoming reviews and boosted to the top rank by accident’—in this self-assessment, Mr He humbly downplayed his own input, especially in terms of the well-thought interior design and his unique approach to roasting locally sourced coffee beans. Mr He’s opinion on the term *wanghong* also shifted over time:

I originally designed this café to specifically imitate Song Dynasty architecture . . . During the peak of its popularity, we had a lot of younger visitors who came here to take pictures and told me they appreciated the Japanese style of wooden architecture [some Dianping reviews dubbed the café ‘a Japanese café in Hangzhou’] . . . Sometimes I was very close to getting angry, so I asked them to leave, and I banned photography indoors for a while . . . Now I have come to terms with *wanghong*, and I realise that it is exactly these people who misinterpret [me] who are hyping the café online. [translation is my own]

Mr He argues that the interior design was understood by most of his customers as a publicly shared ‘feeling’ (*ganjue*) but never clearly defined. His original intention was to gradually merge the café into the historical neighbourhood while nurturing a group of regular patrons at his own pace—‘slow but long-lasting’. However, in 2021 and 2022, the neighbourhood of Xiaohe Zhijie itself was catapulted into *wanghong* status, to which the café also contributed a significant amount of online attention. More cafés, teahouses, and ice cream shops popped up on the historic street in the last two years. Most of them did not last more than six months, but more investments poured in to replace the failed cafés and shops.

Among this wave of new cafés, homogenising interior design and poorly maintained product quality were the common issues. According to Mr He, the cafés and teahouses that attempted to replicate the *wanghong* model never intended to last long and often didn’t. This is not necessarily a problem for the business owners since they can restart the process in another location once they exhaust the design fad and initial popularity in the last location. The high turnover rate, however, limits or even damages the possibility of building an enduring local community around these cafés. According to Mr He, the internet fame of the *wanghong* café is too reliant on algorithmic recommendations and rankings as they consequently

circumvent cultivating a local culture or habit of coffee consumption. It further creates an impression of coffee and the space of the coffeehouse as a novelty—‘a petite bourgeois imaginary’ that displaces coffee from being a daily commodity. Mr He’s initial rejection of *wanghong* ironically backfired, as his eagerness to participate in the local governance unintentionally accelerated the gentrification, which then failed at sustaining its mindless replication of *wanghong* aesthetics. The following case of Tianmuli is another example of setting the trend of the *wanghong* machine, not just via design, but also through contemporary art.

Wanghong Machine from Pompidou to Tianmuli

Tianmuli or OōEli is a commercial and art multifunctional complex in Hangzhou. Consisting of seventeen buildings and an ‘oasis-like’ public square in the middle, aptly named the ‘city lobby’, the cluster of Tianmuli boasts one art museum, a bookshop, a hotel, multiple art galleries, various public art installation, event spaces, office buildings (including the headquarter of the fashion group JNBY), cafés, bars, and restaurants. Tianmuli was designed by Renzo Piano and the whole site highlights ‘glass, aluminium panels, architectural concrete and vertical greenery’ (INDiplomacy 2020) in a rather unified and *hygienic* manner, featuring exterior walls made of anodised aluminium panels, fair-faced concrete ceilings, omnipresent geothermal wells, rooftop gardens, green buildings filled with tea trees, a selection of various plants from all over the world in the square, and infinity pools sectioned by pedestrian paths. In a bird-eye’s view, the ordering of trees, mirror pools, and wayfarers are aligned to be reminiscent of a traditional Hangzhou garden, but it also resembles a ‘sand table’ architectural model partly due to the sheer number of visitors staying still and posing for photos (see Figure 14.5).

Since its opening, the multifunctional complex was quickly labelled as a *wanghong* space on Dianping and Xiaohongshu by its army of reviewers and fashion influencers, who frequented the site to *daka* (literally ‘punching the card’), sometimes with luggage full of clothes to swap. *Daka* refers to going to a location purely to leave photographic evidence online to prove that you have been there. Here lies a recurrent keyword in the posts about how photogenic Tianmuli is—high *chupianlv*, literally ‘rate of out [successful] photos’. The rate refers to the number of photos that are satisfactory enough to be posted online, divided by the total number of photos taken. The obsession with *chupianlv* does not just apply to professional fashion photography but also to ordinary users who post their photos on Dianping and other platforms. Among the hundreds of Dianping user-generated posts attached to #tianmuli I collected, there are not only posts introducing the different galleries, shows, shops, and architecture, but also specific instructions on how and where to take better photos in Tianmuli: ‘concrete walls look good for portrait-mode’; ‘the mirror-like infinity pools look good through a wide-angle lens’; ‘this pose is perfect in front of the entrance of this particular building’. I am not suggesting the design of

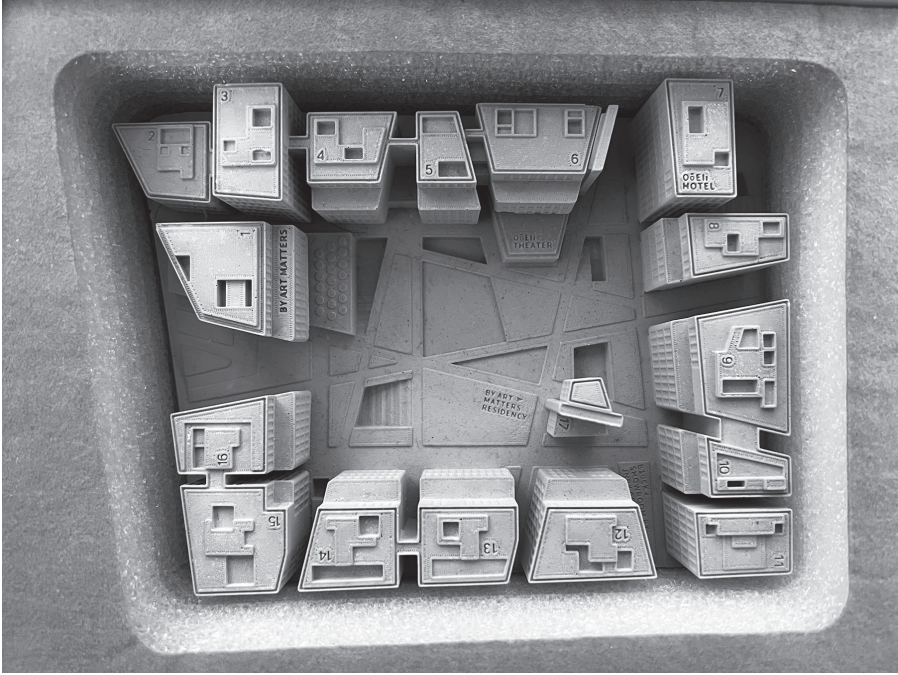


Figure 14.5: A miniature of Tianmuli released by JNBY. Photo by the author.

Tianmuli is necessarily impacted by the algorithmic logic of what is considered aesthetically pleasing. However, the circular logic of the postdigital condition is complete when the design of Tianmuli seamlessly blends into the timeline micropolitics of Dianping and Xiaohongshu.

Tianmuli is not a classic example of gentrification under the frame of creative/cultural industrial clusters like Beijing's 798 Art District and OCAT Shenzhen, which are both transformed from actual factories. As Zhang (2018) captures the 798 Art District's history of contested placemaking between municipal governments, artists, landlords, and so forth, the making of these cultural-industrial clusters was always provisional and precarious. The placemaking of these clusters often eclipses the actual art and artists and instead highlights their historical, urban, and architectural significance. In contrast, Tianmuli was not converted from an industrial building or factory but was built from the ground up to simulate the aesthetics of futuristic industrialism. In particular, Tianmuli strives to make a difference in the aspect of artistic production, as the official website (www.ooeli.com) reads: 'Tianmuli: making a generator of art events.'

This line reminds me of another building that Renzo Piano was famous for—the Pompidou Centre. The aspirational description of Tianmuli curiously echoes

Jean Baudrillard's (1994, 61) derisive comment on Pompidou: 'Beaubourg machine' is 'a machine for making emptiness.' Following Baudrillard, the meticulously crafted spatiality of Tianmuli is also 'a monument of cultural deterrence' (Baudrillard 1994, 65)—'the very ideology of "cultural production" (exactly the aim of these cultural-industrial clusters) is antithetical to all culture' (Baudrillard 1994, 64). The inaugural show of the Tianmuli Art Museum, 'a show about nothing', in 2022 ironically exhibits the nothingness of this 'unconditional aestheticization' (Baudrillard 1994, 68). As the show invites visitors to leave their own traces by leaving signatures on the wall and pressing their limbs against a wall made of velvet carpet, the show was certainly reflexive of the 'influencerizing' imperative: 'What looks best for the time-lapse? What is the most aesthetically appealing backdrop?' (Bishop 2022)—in short, generating a high rate of good-looking photos. The production of space in Tianmuli is fundamentally tied to the postdigital process of endlessly celebrifying the space. No matter how the space itself rejects or at least shuns the adjective of *wanghong*, Tianmuli helps set or update the aesthetic standard of *wanghong*.

As Baudrillard (1994, 66) writes, 'The only content of Beaubourg is the masses themselves, whom the building treats like a converter . . . just like a refinery handles petroleum products.' Tianmuli's content is literally the 'content creators'. The masses consume the algorithmically augmented (via filters) and circulated (via self-replicating recommendations) images of themselves while the space is not only a backdrop but also a converter that turns ordinary people into influencers (not necessarily in the professional/entrepreneurial sense but in terms of behaviours and mentality) and moulds our sensibilities and perceptions of pleasure and beauty. Going back to Wang Xiaofeng's (2015) critique of 'mass culture [in China] only has the masses but no culture', his view comes from the elitism of a cultural critic, but it does hint at a major shift in Chinese society—'the production of the masses' (Baudrillard 1994, 68). The mass production of *wanghong* cafés outlined in the previous section is intertwined with the production of *massive affect*—the *feelings* of aesthetic pleasure that cannot be precisely defined. Tianmuli is the spectacle of how a distinct design language, intentionally or not, launches a *wanghong* trend but this design is, much like Mr He's café, (mis)interpreted in ambiguous if not inaccurate descriptors. This massive affect often deflects theoretical analysis but can be captured algorithmically via discrete design traits.

***Wanghong*: 'A Term That Sucks but Is Useful'**

From the outset, *wanghong* as an adjective is akin to global trends such as 'Instagrammable' architecture but it is now much more intertwined with the post-digital society of contemporary China. *Wanghong* as both a logic and aesthetic is not unique to China in its origin but its scale, ubiquity, and societal impact are. The ascension of *wanghong* as a universal concept has now attracted much academic discussion but 'in almost all contexts, though, it suggests a certain shallowness. A

hollow facade.’ (Chaoyang Trap House, 2021). Mr He and a curator at the Tianmulu Art Museum both expressed a certain unwillingness to cast *wanghong* in a positive light; in other words, they respectfully hid their hostility and expressed only neutrality towards *wanghong* behaviours (e.g., taking photos) within a parameter: for the curator, as long as they don’t disrupt the art exhibitions; for the café owner Mr He, as long as they do not disturb the atmosphere of the usually quiet café. In this case, *wanghong* comes across as an awkward but useful buzzword; never intended to accurately capture consistent meanings but instead communicate public feelings.

This uneasiness with *wanghong* as people or behaviour is gradually replaced with a sheer lassitude: *wanghong* as an aesthetic-economic-algorithmic model is simply not sustainable. The expanding scale of replicating *wanghong* aesthetics and overwhelming homogeneity began to have a real impact on everyday operations of these spaces, not dissimilar to gentrification—from suspending older community practices to a fast turnover rate of economic, social, and spatial ruination. To a certain degree, the concept of *wanghong* shares the same stimulation and fatigue with the hype of the postdigital as a concept in the art world. The postdigital aesthetics have ‘no value of its own, including no particular association with technological or social progress’; ‘used as a convenience but typically associated with aesthetic shortcomings’; ‘avoided in the perceivable work but implicitly present as a tool of its creation or a tacit negative reference’ (Cramer 2013). *Wanghong* aesthetics share the same ambiguities. While possessing economic potential and practical tangibility (streamlined and easy-to-replicate design), *wanghong* aesthetics do not create a new distinct aesthetic movement nor socioeconomically sustainable ‘progress’. The *wanghong* machine is speculative not just via human experimentations, but also via algorithmic indexicality. The presentation of the design itself, regardless of their original intentions and preferences, is often enclosed under the same buzzword or a cluster of buzzwords. While the digital appears to be totalising from the compulsory smartphone to platform-directed urban exploration to the circular feedback of design replication, it is also important to see the discrete parts of the *wanghong* machine as I outlined earlier.

Between the social stigma and romanticism of it as an academic enterprise, the concept of *wanghong* certainly sucks for the curators and designers, who want to escape the socioeconomic and aesthetic paradigm of *wanghong* but often must capitulate to its mass culture. However, it is useful as a conduit to understanding contemporary Chinese society where everything can be and is incessantly celebrated and aestheticised in an algorithmically directed circular process. Since the concept of *wanghong* itself detests longevity, whatever idealism and materialism thrown at it becomes banal within the larger socioeconomic schemes and tidal waves of massive affect. This chapter does not necessarily capture a period of fundamental change in our perception of aesthetics, but instead focuses on how far removed contemporary aesthetic theory is from the realities of both everyday and celebrity culture in China.

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